Harrison getting mad at you again like he did in the dressing room after we'd lost at Elland Road.

By then, the 1992/93 season, the players in our age group were starting to get involved, and to get games, with the first team. As early as September, I got called into training with the senior players and, a couple of days later, the manager told me that I would be traveling to Brighton for a League Cup tie. Gary, Nicky Butt and Paul Scholes were coming as well. We flew down on this little seventeen-seater plane. It was a horrible flight: the noise, the bumping, the cramped seats, and it seemed to go on forever. Maybe that was why I got such a great night's sleep once we'd finally arrived. I woke up to the news that I was going to be one of the substitutes.

About twenty minutes from the end, the manager told me I was going on in place of Andrei Kanchelskis. I was so excited I jumped off the bench and cracked my head on the roof of the dugout: a great start to a first-team career. The boss wanted to have a look at me and I think I did all right. Mum and Dad were at the ground and they were as surprised as I was that I actually got a game. Seventeen minutes as a United player, but I still felt really young. What was I? Just seventeen? More like the boy who'd been on the bench at West Ham as a mascot than a man ready to be in United's first team. The manager had a little go at me in the dressing room afterwards. I don't remember having done anything wrong. He was probably just trying to make sure I didn't get full of myself: a sign of one or two difficult times, maybe, that lay ahead for us further down the line.

It was a long time before I got another chance. The Youth Cup side had all moved up to reserve team soccer: we'd won the 'A' League and then the Central League, the first time the club had done that in over twenty years. I played in some League Cup games again early on in the 1994/95 season, when the manager rested his first-choice players. Back in the early nineties, United struggled a bit in Europe because of the Overseas Players Rule, which meant you could only play three foreigners in the European Cup. It wasn't that we didn't have a strong squad, but the changes the boss had to make would disrupt the rhythm of the side. That particular season, we were already as good as out of the competition but had a home game against Galatasaray still to play. It was early December.

The first I knew about the possibility of me being involved was an article in the *Manchester Evening News* saying the manager was thinking about giving some youngsters a chance to try European soccer. On the day, he told a few of us we'd actually start the game that night. I don't know about the